

Slovakia



Slovakia was the rural and poorer half of Czechoslovakia, and after its independence in 1993, the country suffered economically. Much of the land is mountainous and forested. About half is used for crops or grazing, but industry now employs a large number of workers. Most people are Slovaks, speaking their own language, but there are also some Roma and Czechs, as well as a nine per cent Hungarian minority.

Bratislava

From 1536 to 1784, Bratislava was the capital of Hungary. Now it is the capital of an independent Slovakia. The city was founded in the 10th century, and has had a university since 1467. The new parliament buildings were once the home of an archbishop. Bratislava is a Danube river port and a rail centre. Its factories make chemicals and engineering goods.



Rural life

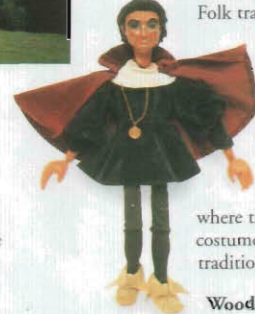
The Slovakian countryside is a mixture of mountain villages, ancient walled towns, and castles. There are still many large state-run farms, but about 20 per cent of the land is farmed by tiny, family-run concerns. The main crops are potatoes, sugar beet, and grains. Rural life is hard, and poverty is common, driving increasing numbers of young people to towns in search of work.

SLOVAKIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Bratislava
AREA	49,500 sq km (19,100 sq miles)
POPULATION	5,400,000
MAIN LANGUAGE	Slovak
MAJOR RELIGION	Christian
CURRENCY	Koruna

Folklore

Folk traditions are strong in Slovakia, where puppet shows are popular. The former Czechoslovakia is acknowledged as the original home of European puppetry. The Slovakian people enjoy folk festivals where they can dress in regional costumes and sing and dance to traditional music.



Wooden puppet

Hungary



Hungary was formed about a thousand years ago by the Magyars, an ethnic group from Russia that makes up 90 per cent of today's population. Hungary was communist from 1945 until 1990, and since then its industries have had to compete on the world market. The country's skilled scientists and engineers have succeeded in attracting foreign investment.



Wine

Hungary is a world-class wine producer and exports a wide range of high-quality red and white wines. The best known Hungarian wine is Tokay, pronounced tok-eye. It is a sweet, rich, golden wine, widely believed to be healthful. Another well-known Hungarian wine is Bull's Blood, so-called for its dark blood-red colour.



Thermal springs

Hungary has hundreds of hot thermal springs; their warm mineral waters are said to have medicinal properties. The country has more than 150 spring baths, which are open to the public.



Paprika

Hungarians grow more than 40 per cent of the world's paprika, a sweet, bright-red pepper used in cooking. One town, Kalocsa in southern Hungary, even has a museum devoted entirely to this spice. Paprika originally came from Central America. Hungarian farmers also grow rye, corn, wheat, barley, sugar beets, and potatoes, as well as grapes, olives, and figs. Sunflowers are grown for their oil.

Goulash

Hungary's most famous dish is goulash, a stew of beef with vegetables, flavoured and coloured with paprika. A pork version is called *pörkölt*. Other traditional dishes with paprika include bacon and potato casserole, and chicken paprikash.

Goulash is a traditional Hungarian stew.



Budapest

Straddling the Danube, Budapest is two cities in one – Buda on the hilly right bank, and Pest on the low-lying left bank. Buda was the old royal capital of Hungary, and has fine old buildings and the remains of a Roman town. Pest is the country's administrative and industrial centre.



The Parliament buildings in Pest, viewed from Buda



Horse breeding

Hungary has a long tradition of horse breeding, located at the great stud farms at Mezöhegyes and Bábolna. The best-known Hungarian breeds are the Nonius and Furioso, which were developed at Mezöhegyes, and the Shagya Arab at Bábolna. Today, these stud farms develop horses for taking part in shows.

Hungary's oldest stud farm at Mezöhegyes

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